Phonotactics & Alternations

Dr. Josef Fruehwald

Possible vs Impossible Words

When you know a language's sound system, you know more than just the actual words. You also know what are *impossible* words for that language.

Possible vs Impossible Words

English

Actual words		Possible words	Impossible words
meaning	phonemes	phonemes	phonemes
dog	/dɔg/	/dɑɹg/	/ndɔg/
blue	/bluː/	/blɪk/	/tlɪk/

Possible vs Impossible Words

/blɪk/ vs */tlɪk/

- Neither are actual words of English.
- They're both physically possible to pronounce.
- These are both possible words in *some* languages.
- One thing you just *know*, when you know English, is that */tl/ is not a possible onset.

Phonotactic Constraints

Phono-

Sound

-tactic

touching

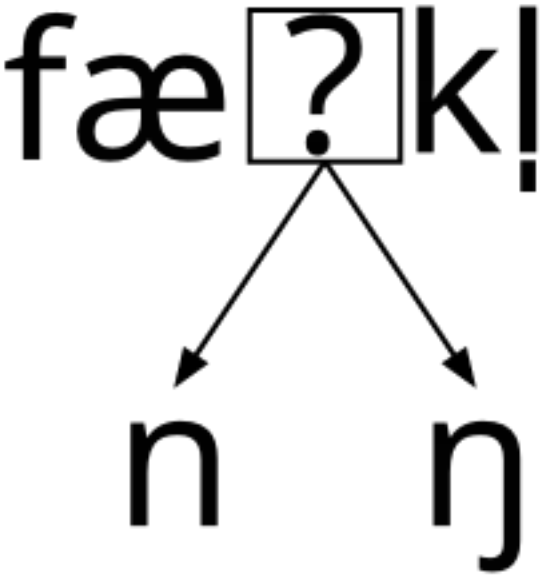
Phonotactic Constraints

There's more to it than just the *absence* of a sequence of sounds.

fl		fr		vl		vr
flee	fli:	*free*	fɹi:	*vlog*	vlɑg	??
flute	flut	*fry*	fɹaɪ			

Phonotactic Constraints

"fankle" is a word sometimes used in Scotland that means "to get all tangled up."



Phonotactic Constraints

Nasal Assimilation is a really common kind of phonotactic repair.

Phonotactic repairs can sometimes lead to alternations.

Alternations

un-	/ʌn/

undone	ʌndʌn	*uncaring*	ʌŋkeɹɪŋ	*unpopular*	ʌmpɑpjulɻ
untold	ʌntold	*uncool*	ʌŋkul	*unpaid*	ʌmpeɪd

Alternations

Alternations Handout

Common Kinds of Alternations

Some kinds of alternations are so common they have specific names:

Assimilation
: Two segments becoming more similar

Dissimilation
: Two segments becoming more different

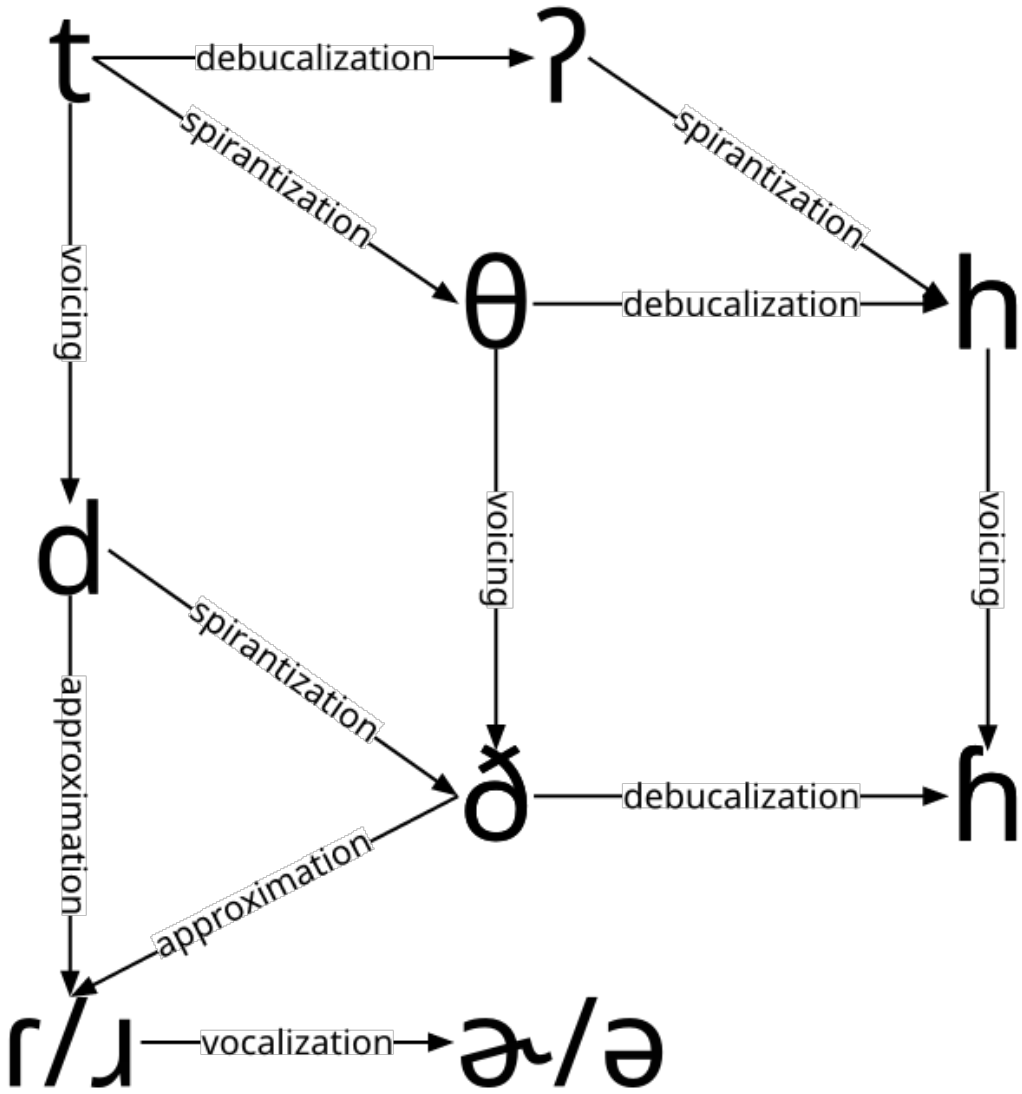
Lenition
: Weakening (becoming more sonorous)

Fortition
: Strengthening (becoming less sonorous)

Deletion
: Deletion of a segment

Epenthesis
: Insertion of a segment

Lenition


t
debucalization
ʔ
spirantization
spirantization
voicing
θ
debucalization
h
ɖ
voicing
voicing
spirantization
approximation
ð
debucalization
ɦ
approximation
ɾ/ɹ
vocalization
ə̯/ə